

traffic, are almost impossible to detect because the hacker never joins your network. They can sit silently with their antenna tuned into your network and capture gigabytes of network traffic for off-line analysis at a later time. Active attacks, where the hacker joins the network, can be the most devastating because they can launch active attacks into the network and onto your devices on the network.

There are five attacks that hackers can very easily and readily perform on your wireless network with very little effort or expense. The first two are passive attacks, and the last three are active attacks. But make no mistake—all these attacks can be deadly.

Deadly Attack #1: Account And Password Capture

There are several applications that send your account and passwords in clear text over the network. For example, every time a POP3 mail account checks for new e-mail, the account name and password are in the clear as part of the data transfer. Anyone sniffing the network traffic can easily get your e-mail account information. Once they have that information, they can access your e-mail account at their leisure, monitoring for personal information without leaving a trace. From there, any confidential information they can get from your account just escalates their attack.

Deadly Attack #2: E-mail, IM And Web Site Traffic Capture

It is very easy to monitor and capture all of the e-mail traffic sent over an unsecured wireless network. Since most e-mail is sent in clear-text, and instant messaging is sent in HTML, it's very simple to capture the traffic and mine the traffic offline for any "interesting" information at a later time. By monitoring your wireless traffic, all of the HTML data can be captured and reconstituted as web pages on the hackers PC to see exactly what web sites and content you are surfing over the wireless network.

Deadly Attack #3: Accessing Data On Your PC

Let's face it, it's pretty easy to turn File Sharing on, and then forget to turn it off when you attach to an Open Network. Once File